

SUPREME SYNERGY

# The 7 Most Common Mistakes Spiritual Teachers and Coaches Make

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*and how they show up in your life*

Tony Robbins. Mel Robbins. James Clear. Andrew Huberman. David Goggins. *The Secret*. Joe Dispenza. Gabby Bernstein. Byron Katie. *A Course in Miracles*. Bryan Johnson. What each one gets right, and the half they leave out.

Braxton Luke

# Before you read

If Neo had Tony Robbins as his coach, he would never have left the Matrix. He would have become CEO of the company he worked for, inside it.

Have you ever done everything a teacher told you to do, felt it work for a few weeks, and then watched the same problem come back wearing different clothes?

Here is what I think is going on.

Every teacher on the next pages is teaching something real. I have learned from all of them. The mistake is not the piece they teach. The mistake is teaching the piece as if it were the whole. Each piece has a blind spot, and the blind spot shows up in the student as a specific symptom. Then the student blames themselves, because the teaching told them the piece was everything.

Number seven is the one that explains the other six.

The people named here are not villains. They were handed an incomplete picture of how life works, the same as you, the same as me. I am naming them because you already know their work, and a pattern is easier to see on a face you recognize.

## MISTAKE 1

# “You attracted it.”

**Who says it.** Rhonda Byrne, in *The Secret* (2006), thirty million copies and counting: “Everything that’s coming into your life you are attracting into your life.” Gabby Bernstein sells the gentler version in *Super Attractor*, honest about her own recovery and built as a daily practice of feeling good first: “What others have is a reflection of what is on the way for you.”

**What’s right about it.** Where you put your attention changes what you notice, what you try, and what you walk right past. Expecting something changes how you show up for it. For the person who has never once asked for anything, who waits to be picked, this book is a door. It got a lot of people to say what they want out loud for the first time in their lives.

**What it leaves out.** Everything else that causes things. Your body. Other people’s choices. What happened to you before you were old enough to choose anything. The book says the law applies to everything coming into your life, and “everything” is exactly where it breaks.

**How it shows up in you.** Something bad happens and you get hurt twice. Once by the thing itself, and again by the question you were taught to ask: *what did I do to attract this?* The second hurt is shame. Pain is something you can work with. Shame just makes you hide it.

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*Your part is real. So is everything else in the room.*

**One question.** *What did the baby attract?*

## MISTAKE 2

# “Everything that bothers you is a mirror.”

**Who says it.** Byron Katie, in *Loving What Is* (2002). Her method, The Work, is four questions and a turnaround, and one of its turnarounds takes the judgment you hold about someone and turns it back toward yourself. “When you argue with reality, you lose, but only 100% of the time.”

**What’s right about it.** A lot of what sets you off is old pain wearing a new face, and putting a thought on the table and asking *is it true?* is one of the most useful tools there is. For the person tyrannized by their own stories, the one who has been arguing with a dead parent for twenty years, this is real relief, fast.

**What it leaves out.** Some of what’s out there is really out there. The turnaround assumes the problem is always on your side of the glass. Some people are not a lesson. They are a warning. And a tool built to dissolve your story about someone will dissolve the true stories too.

**How it shows up in you.** You stay too long. In the relationship, the job, the group. You keep working on yourself over something your gut was right about from the start. Eventually you stop trusting your gut at all, because every time it spoke, you were taught to turn it around.

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*The mirror is real. So is the window.*

**One question.** *What would count as not-you?*

### MISTAKE 3

## “Rise above it. None of it is real.”

**Who says it.** *A Course in Miracles* (1976), the book Marianne Williamson carried to millions. It opens with: “Nothing real can be threatened. Nothing unreal exists.” From there the whole world of bodies, time and loss is called perception, not truth.

**What’s right about it.** There is a part of you that can watch a feeling without drowning in it, and finding that part is one of the great reliefs there is. Fear and love as the two postures you can take toward anything: true, and useful. Forgiveness setting the forgiver free: true. For someone locked in resentment, or in an old religious wound, this book has been a way out.

**What it leaves out.** Your body. You can watch the reaction from a great height, and your body is still down there, bracing, the way it learned to. Watching a feeling is not the same as your body finishing it. The bruise is real, and something in you knows the difference between peace and not feeling.

**How it shows up in you.** Calm on the cushion, the same snap in the same argument. Or a peace that is really numbness: you stopped feeling it instead of getting through it. The people close to you can tell. You are the last to know.

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*The calm watcher is real. So is the body that’s still bracing.*

**One question.** *Would you say it at a hospital bed?*

## “Change your state. Condition your mind.”

**Who says it.** Tony Robbins, most famously, and the school he learned it from, NLP, which trains a new habit the way you would train a reflex. In *Awaken the Giant Within* (1991): “Emotion is created by motion.” Change the body and the state changes, in a minute. Step three of his change method is “Interrupt the Limiting Pattern.” The engine under all of it is pain and pleasure: “Everything you and I do, we do either out of our need to avoid pain or our desire to gain pleasure.” Joe Dispenza teaches the meditation version of the same move, in his words “programming a new personality to a new personal reality.” Mel Robbins built a career on the interrupt alone, and it works: “If you have an instinct to act on a goal, you must physically move within 5 seconds or your brain will kill it.” Five, four, three, two, one, and you are moving before the old pattern gets a vote.

**What’s right about it.** State is real, and it is the most under-used lever there is. Move your body, change your breathing, stand differently, and the thought you were stuck in loses half its grip. That is true, and it works on day one. “Knowing is not enough” is true. Leverage, making the cost of not changing bigger than the cost of changing, is how most real change actually starts.

I know this one from the inside. A few years ago I was knocking on strangers’ doors for a living, and I listened to *Personal Power* in the car on the way to the neighborhood. It worked. I knocked more doors and I closed more of them. It got me off the couch, and it does that for the person who knows exactly what to do and still doesn’t do it.

**What it leaves out.** The mind gets treated like something to be trained. Pain here, pleasure there, interrupt the old pattern, install the new one, repeat until it sticks. He is honest about where that comes

from. It is Pavlov, the man with the dogs, and it works on people for the same reason it worked on the dogs.

Two things go missing. First, the one holding the leash. Nobody asks where your wants came from, whether you chose them, or whether they were installed before you were old enough to say no. So you get very good at chasing what you were already trained to chase. Second, the low state itself. A bad feeling is usually information. Interrupt it fast enough, often enough, and you never find out what it was trying to tell you. You escape the state without finishing it.

Back to Neo, the CEO. Peak state, elite habits, massive action, better every year at a game that was rigged before he sat down. He never walks out. He never becomes a warrior of love, the one who frees everyone else from the machines. The training was real. It was aimed at winning the wrong game.

**How it shows up in you.** The peak state on Monday is flat by Thursday, so you go back for another hit of it. You get more of what you wanted, and it does not feel like what you were promised. You win and you are still empty, so you decide the goal must have been too small, and set a bigger one. Same loop, more horsepower.

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*Training your mind is real. So is asking who holds the leash.*

**One question.** *Who taught you to want that?*

## MISTAKE 5

# “Track it. Improve it. Repeat.”

**Who says it.** Bryan Johnson, the tech founder spending millions a year to slow his own aging, with a protocol called Blueprint and a slogan, “Don’t Die.” He says: “I’ve built an algorithm that takes better care of me than I can myself.” And: “My mind observes. My mind no longer decides.” Andrew Huberman runs the mainstream version, put the mechanisms out free with the studies attached, and calls his book “an operating manual for the human body.”

**What’s right about it.** Sleep, food, training and habits are real levers, and measuring them works. Johnson is not guessing: he publishes his numbers. Between them they got a lot of people to take sleep seriously for the first time, which is the right medicine for anyone who has never measured anything and is guessing. That is a real gift.

**What it leaves out.** The person doing the measuring, and what all of it is for. When the mind no longer decides, the numbers do, and the numbers do not know what a life is for. They only know up and down. An operating manual tells you how to run the machine. It cannot tell you where to drive it.

**How it shows up in you.** The numbers go up and something is still missing. You hit the goal, feel it for a day, and set the next one. Doing great on paper, empty in person. You can tell, because you check the app before you check how you feel.

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*The numbers are real. So is the person they’re supposed to be for.*

**One question.** *When did you last check how you feel before you checked the app?*

## MISTAKE 6

# “Discipline. Push through.”

**Who says it.** David Goggins, in *Can't Hurt Me* (2018). The 40% rule: when you think you are done, you are at forty percent of what your body can do. The fix, in his words, is to “callous your mind, day after day,” and to “chase pain like it’s your damn job.” Jocko Willink put the same idea on a book cover: *Discipline Equals Freedom*.

**What’s right about it.** Nothing gets built without effort, and your mood is a bad boss. You are capable of far more than the first *I’m done* tells you. Goggins earned every word of that with his own life, and for a person who quits at the first discomfort, he is the right medicine.

**What it leaves out.** Direction. And what your tiredness is trying to tell you. A calloused hand feels less. A calloused mind feels less too, and the thing it stops feeling is the signal that says *wrong way*. Pushing through is only a virtue if you are pointed somewhere worth arriving.

**How it shows up in you.** You row harder and get nowhere faster, because you are pointed the wrong way. Sleep that does not refresh you. Living for the weekend. Burning out and calling it weakness, then pushing harder to prove it wasn’t.

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*Effort is real. So is the direction it’s pointed.*

**One question.** *Harder at what, exactly?*

## “Here’s the answer.”

**Who says it.** All of them. Me too, on my worst days.

**What’s right about it.** Every one of the six above teaches a real piece, and I would hand any of them to the right person on the right day.

The most honest of them shows the gap best. James Clear’s *Atomic Habits* is the best tool book of the decade, and he set its scope on purpose. His method is two steps: “Decide the type of person you want to be. Prove it to yourself with small wins.” Step one is one sentence long. The rest of the book is step two. Which habits, which person, what for: he leaves that to you, and says so. That is not a mistake. It is the gap, drawn by the one writer careful enough not to paper over it.

**What it leaves out.** The other pieces, and the picture that shows how they fit together. It is like being handed a puzzle one piece at a time by six different people, and nobody ever shows you the picture on the box. Not because they are hiding it. Nobody showed them either. Every teacher above is working from a partial picture, and so were the people who taught them. That picture on the box, how your life actually fits together, is what I mean by the map. A map is for going somewhere: this one shows you what is worth protecting, and what it takes to protect it.

**How it shows up in you.** You have tried a lot. Each thing worked for a few weeks. Then the same problem, the same bottleneck, the same pattern again. You start to suspect you are the one thing that can’t be fixed. You are not. You were handed pieces sold as the whole.

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*You were handed a map before you could evaluate it. So were the people who handed it to you. The original was better, and it is still yours.*

**One question.** *Who showed you the box?*

# What you have now

Seven halves, and one question for each. Keep the one that stung.

| THE MISSING HALF                                                                               | THE QUESTION                                                            |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 Your part is real. So is everything else in the room.                                        | <i>What did the baby attract?</i>                                       |
| 2 The mirror is real. So is the window.                                                        | <i>What would count as not-you?</i>                                     |
| 3 The calm watcher is real. So is the body that's still bracing.                               | <i>Would you say it at a hospital bed?</i>                              |
| 4 Training your mind is real. So is asking who holds the leash.                                | <i>Who taught you to want that?</i>                                     |
| 5 The numbers are real. So is the person they're supposed to be for.                           | <i>When did you last check how you feel before you checked the app?</i> |
| 6 Effort is real. So is the direction it's pointed.                                            | <i>Harder at what, exactly?</i>                                         |
| 7 You were handed a map before you could evaluate it. So were the people who handed it to you. | <i>Who showed you the box?</i>                                          |

Every one of these is a half. The map is the thing they are halves of.

# What to do with this

Pick the one that stung. Not the one you agree with, the one that stung. That is the piece you were sold as the whole, and the symptom next to it is your door.

Then write back with its number. Reply to the email this came in, or message me on Instagram, **@braxtonluke**. I read them, and the date of the live presentation, where I show the picture on the box, goes to the people who wrote back first.

*Find what is worth protecting. Then become strong enough to protect it.*

The book this comes from: *The Broken Map, Part One*, at [supremesynergy.org/broken-map](https://supremesynergy.org/broken-map). Characters and works named in these pages belong to their owners and are mentioned for commentary.

# Sources

Every quote above is from the named book, or from the person's own words in an interview.

1. Rhonda Byrne, *The Secret* (2006). Gabrielle Bernstein, *Super Attractor* (2019).
2. Byron Katie with Stephen Mitchell, *Loving What Is* (2002).
3. *A Course in Miracles* (1976), Text, Introduction. Marianne Williamson, *A Return to Love* (1992).
4. Anthony Robbins, *Awaken the Giant Within* (1991), where he credits Pavlov and Skinner for the conditioning model; *Personal Power* (1989). Joe Dispenza, *Becoming Supernatural* (2017). Mel Robbins, *The 5 Second Rule* (2017) and *The Let Them Theory* (2024).
5. Bryan Johnson, interviewed in *Rolling Stone* (2023) and in later interviews on Blueprint. Andrew Huberman, [hubermanlab.com](https://hubermanlab.com), and *Protocols: An Operating Manual for the Human Body* (2025).
6. David Goggins, *Can't Hurt Me* (2018). Jocko Willink, *Discipline Equals Freedom* (2017).
7. James Clear, *Atomic Habits* (2018), the chapter on identity. The last line of Mistake 7 is mine.